

Week 5: Plot in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Every scene in the Bible sits inside a bigger story — tonight we'll look at how paying attention to that changes what a passage means.

1. Have you ever badly misread a movie or book because you only caught one scene out of context — like walking into a film halfway through? What happened once you finally saw the whole thing?
2. **Read Judges 6.** What is Gideon doing when the angel first finds him, and what does he ask God for before he'll act on what he's been told? What does this opening chapter reveal about Gideon's character, even before any fighting starts?
3. The famous "fleece" scene is often taught as a model for how to discern God's will. But read in context, it looks more like Gideon repeatedly testing God out of fear rather than acting in faith. Does knowing the larger story change how you'd apply this scene to your own life?
4. **Read Judges 7.** What two rounds of cuts does God make to Gideon's army, and how does he decide who stays each time? Given what we already know about Gideon's hesitance, why do you think God insisted on doing this?
5. The battle is won with trumpets, torches, and clay jars instead of weapons or superior numbers. What point do you think the author is making about where real power actually comes from?
6. **Read Judges 8.** What does Gideon say when Israel offers to make him king, and what does he do right afterward with the gold earrings they give him? How does this ending complicate a simple "hero wins the day" reading of Gideon's story?
7. Some readers describe biblical plots as following either a "comedy" arc (a character overcomes challenges and rises) or a "tragedy" arc (a character has everything going for them but self-destructs). Looking at the whole span of Judges 6-8, which arc do you think best fits Gideon, and why?

8. This one story about Gideon sits inside the larger book of Judges, which itself sits inside the larger story of Israel repeatedly failing and needing rescue. How does seeing Gideon as one piece of that bigger, repeating pattern change what you think the story is actually about?
9. Think of a familiar Bible story you've mostly encountered in bite-sized pieces — a sermon point, a devotional, a kids' Bible version. What might change if you read the whole surrounding narrative in one sitting instead?